

the case may be), and click Configure. What you need to change is the “Buffer-Ahead on track change.” If you set the Buffer-Ahead to 5000 ms, Winamp will begin reading the next track when the current track has five seconds left, allowing for a smooth transition. If, however, your computer is low on memory, you’re better off leaving this setting at the default.

Another interesting setting here is Fading, in the Fading tab. It’s irritating to have a song end abruptly, and you can control that here. There are too many options for us to discuss here, but suffice it to say that you can control every aspect of fading you can think of—including whether or not to fade while you’re seeking, that is, moving the slider to a part of a song!

The options under Other in DirectSound (or waveOut) output are interesting. Here you’ll be able to remove the silence at the beginning or ending of tracks—and you can specify what Winamp interprets as silence. You can choose to have the volume control behave in a smooth manner, and you can choose between a logarithmic and a linear volume control. This is similar to the logarithmic/linear choice for the equaliser we talked about.

Winamp has SHOUTcast support, and can ably act as your SHOUTcast client. SHOUTcast is free Internet radio—visit www.shoutcast.com: there’s all the genres you can think of, and when you click on a result with Winamp on, it just plays! You can be a broadcaster as well—check the documentation on the main page for details. Of course, you can also use other media players to listen to SHOUTcast streams.

Coming to the plugins: like we said, they are divided into six categories.

1. Input

These are decoders for various formats. If you find a format Winamp doesn’t support, you’ll probably be able to find a plugin for it.